

Manigiramam, or manigramam, typically refers to a medieval merchant guild organized by itinerant ethnic Indian traders, primarily active in southern India. It is widely attested in the Viraraghava copper plate as being an important trading guild, underscored by its leader, Iravikorttan receiving 72 Royal privileges from the Chera King at the time of its issue. (c. 1225 CE) Along with the ainurruvar (the Ayyavole Five Hundred) and the anjuvannam (the anjuman), the manigiramam played a significant role in the commercial activities of the region. Unlike the anjuvannam, which was confined to the port-towns of southern India, the manigramam operated in both port towns and hinter-land trade centers. Professor M. G. S. Narayanan notes that Iravichathan who received concessions from Rajasimha, Chera ruler of Kodungallur via the Thazekad Copper plates and Iravikorttan, who received them through the Viraraghava copper plates are two separate individuals who obtained trade concessions in 1024 CE and 1225 CE on behalf of Manigramam, alluding to the fact that this specific naming convention could be a corporate, titular name of the guild master. He notes that the title did not automatically pass down from father to son like in a royal succession, but was passed by corporate succession and was usually held inside a powerful Oligarchy of seafaring merchants.

A body of merchants known as "the Vaniggrama" or "Vaniyagrama" is attested in northern India as early as the first century BCE. They are mentioned in a Karle inscription (first century BCE), a charter of king Vishnusena from Kathiawad (6th century CE), and in a Sanjeli charter of king Toramana (6th century CE).

Records of the activities of the manigiramam in southern India can be traced back to the 5th century CE. The earliest references appear in two copper plate grants from south Karnataka (from Melekote, Tumkur and from Hassan district), both datable to the 5th century CE. The Melekote charter records a grant of land to a Buddhist shrine.

The Quilon Syrian copper plates from the 9th century CE also attest to the presence of

manigiramam representatives. By this time, it appears that the manigiramam had become involved in maritime trade and had begun collaborating with the anjuvannam (the anjuman) on the western coast. A Tamil inscription from Takua Pa (9th century CE) in Thailand also references a manigiramam guild.

From the early 10th century onward, the ainurruvar (the Ayyavole Five Hundred) emerged as the dominant merchant guild in southern India. The manigiramam and the anjuvannam were later incorporated into this larger organization. By the 12th century CE, the ainurruvar functioned as an umbrella organization encompassing all other merchant guilds. The manigiramam was fully subordinated to the Ayyavole by the 13th century.

Hermann Gundert argues that Manigramam gained prominence as a Syrian Christian Principality as evidenced by the concessions received by one Maruwan Sapir Iso & Iravikorttan by native rulers of Kerala.

See also

Ainurruvar (the Ayyavole Five Hundred)

Anjuvannam (the Anjuman)

Greater India

History of Indian influence on Southeast Asia

== References ==